

SOUTH KOREA

Very little of South Korea's tender and delicious teas are exported, but it is worth seeking them out. Tea tourists arrive in Korea every year for the festivals that celebrate the delicate new spring teas.

Tea seeds were brought to Korea from China in 828CE and planted on Mount Jiri in South Gyeongsang province, giving birth to a thriving tea culture. In the 16th century, however, when Japan invaded the country, many tea fields were lost. In these and later periods of political turmoil, monks and scholars continued to grow tea in small areas, keeping the tea culture alive. It was only in the early 1960s that interest in tea revived, and tea fields were replanted.

Almost all of South Korea's tea is grown in the mountainous southern part of the peninsula

where it enjoys sea breezes from the Korea Strait and the East Sea.

Most of the tea produced is green tea, picked according to the lunar calendar. Ujeon, made from the earliest pick in mid-April has sweet, soft flavors. Sejak is plucked in early May and has soft but more pronounced flavors. Jungjak is the latest harvest, in mid-to end of May, which gives the liquor a bright jade color and very sweet flavors. Some artisans also produce an aged black tea called Balhyocha, which has flavors of malt, stone fruit, and pine.



BOSEONG

Verdant rows of tea plants in Boseong, a popular tea destination for tourists and considered Korea's tea-growing capital.

SOUTH KOREA KEY FACTS

PERCENTAGE
OF WORLD
PRODUCTION:

0.1%

ELEVATION:

MEDIUM

HARVEST:

MID-APRIL-END MAY

FAMOUS FOR:
SPRING TEA
FESTIVALS

MAIN TYPES:

**GREEN,
MATCHA,
AGED BLACK**



Dried Korean green tea in bamboo baskets waiting to be sorted and packaged.